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of bread: The Bread of Equality”. Over the decades, as wheat became cheaper, baguettes (made of wheat) became common. Pre-revolution, the peasants ate bread made of bran and only the aristocrats ate white bread made of wheat.

One more origin story points to a 1920 French law that prohibited bakers from working between 10 pm and 4 am, which made it impossible to get the bread cooked in time for breakfast, or the bakeries’ opening hours. This was solved by changing the bread into long, thin baguettes that cooked faster. Montay explains that while a baguette takes only 10-15 minutes to bake, a loaf of bread takes an hour. “And that’s just the baking time. The overall process of making a loaf of bread is much longer than that of a baguette,” he says.

Another much-loved myth refers to the construction of the Paris

metro in 1898. Workers from across France were brought to work on the project and they carried knives to cut their loaves of bread. Arguments often led to knife fights. “So, the metro management asked bakers to create a bread that could be torn by hand. The baguette was born and the need for knives was removed,” smiles Rose-lyne Laurent, a Parisian working at a garment export company in Delhi.

Irrespective of which origin story you may believe, long, slim breads have undoubtedly existed in France for a long time. But the baguette was christened so only in 1920. The word baguette is, amongst other things, the French expression for a wizard’s wand or a conductor’s baton—the bread simply takes its name from its shape.

Nobody really knows who invented the modern-day baguette, but it’s said that the man who invented the croissant, Vienna-born baker Au-

gust Zang, aided in the creation of the loaf by installing France’s first steam oven, which allowed for the baking of loaves with a crisp crust and a fluffy centre. The steam oven allowed the crust to expand, which created a lighter and more airy loaf.

So important is the baguette to the French that there is a law governing its creation. “By French law, a baguette must be made with only flour, salt, water and yeast. The size must be 65 cm long, although it can be up to 1 metre long. And, the bread has to be baked on the premises where it is sold. It cannot be frozen and no preservatives can be used,” explains Montay. However, now there are variations where different cereals are added to the wheat, he says.

But for all this precision, making a baguette is a surprisingly simple process. Bakers begin by whisking together water and yeast, then add in the flour and allow a dough to form.